

Pokémon Deckbuilding Game

Tournament Rules v1.1

This document will serve as a guideline for participating in Pokémon Deckbuilding Game tournaments. The following is subject to change and may be overruled by a tournament official.

General Guidelines

Be courteous and respectful to other players and officials. Unsporting behavior is not tolerated and can be grounds for disqualification.

No excessive “backseat gaming.” While deckbuilding games lean more towards the social side, players should ultimately be making their own decisions at the table.

Spectators, eliminated players, and players from other pods should not give strategic advice or comment on hidden/missed information.

There are no “take-backs” once a player begins resolving any card’s text or advances the game state. Judges may still rewind or repair illegal actions when required.

Keep play at a moderate pace. If a player is taking excessively long to perform an action, a judge may issue a warning and enact a timer. Multiple warnings can lead to disqualification.

Cheating is grounds for immediate disqualification and may result in suspension or ban from future events. Examples of cheating include but are not limited to taking illegal game actions, hidden information abuse, intentional misrepresentation of public information, intentionally missing negative mandatory triggers, manipulating randomization, collusion/bribery, or outside assistance.

Policies and details regarding match timers, tardiness, results reporting, appeals, and other topics not covered here are up to the tournament officials for each specific tournament.

If you have any rules or policy questions, please ask a judge or other tournament official.

Table Talk and Politicking

Politicking is a given for most free-for-all games. Collusion however is firmly against the rules and may result in disqualification.

Players may discuss public information, make non-binding strategic suggestions, negotiate in-game actions, and attempt to persuade other players. Players may not reveal hidden information unless a game effect requires it, offer or accept outside-game incentives, predetermine results, agree to prize splits in exchange for in-game actions or concessions, or coordinate with another player to manipulate standings.

Agreements are not enforceable by judges.

Determining Pod Placement

At the end of each game, players are ranked by final XP total.

Ties are broken using the normal game tie breakers: most Challenge cards, then most Pokémon, then most total cards.

If players remain tied after all game tie breakers, the tied players roll a die or flip a coin to determine placement.

Gameplay Specific Reminders

A player may use the shortcut of revealing and playing multiple cards that have no immediate impactful text other than generic +Energy, totaling the Energy gained at once. Cards with other impactful text must be played and resolved one at a time.

Any abilities or effects that are mandatory (do not have the words “may” or “up to”) must be resolved.

Tournament Software

The recommended tournament software for Pokemon Deckbuilding Game is Pod Play.

Tournaments in Pod Play may be run in either Double Elimination or Swiss + Top Cut formats.

Double Elimination

Pod Play’s Double Elimination format adapts the classic two-life tournament structure for multiplayer pod events.

All players begin in the Upper Bracket. Each round, players are assigned to pods where their finishing placement determines advancement.

A first or second place finish allows players to remain in the Upper Bracket.

A third or fourth place finish moves players into the Lower Bracket.

Players in the Lower Bracket continue competing for a path back to the finals.

A player who receives another third or fourth place finish while in the Lower Bracket is eliminated from the tournament.

As the tournament progresses, Pod Play automatically manages Upper and Lower Bracket pairings separately, reducing repeat matchups and creating balanced pods whenever possible.

The Grand Final brings together the two remaining players from the Upper Bracket and the two remaining players from the Lower Bracket for the final pod of the tournament.

Unlike earlier rounds, there is no bracket reset. The player who finishes first in the Grand Final is the tournament winner, and the remaining placements determine the final standings.

Swiss + Top Cut

Pod Play's Swiss + Top Cut format is designed for larger events where organizers want every player to participate through a guaranteed number of rounds before the final elimination stage begins.

Swiss Stage

During the Swiss stage, Pod Play automatically determines the number of rounds based on event size:

8–16 players: 4 Swiss rounds

17–32 players: 5 Swiss rounds

33–64 players: 6 Swiss rounds

65+ players: 7 Swiss rounds

This scaling provides enough rounds to create meaningful standings while keeping tournament length manageable.

Each round, Pod Play creates pods based on current standings so players with similar performance records compete against each other whenever possible. The pairing system also considers previous opponents and seating history to create a better tournament experience.

Players earn points based on their placement:

Four-player pods:

1st place: 7 points

2nd place: 3 points

3rd place: 2 points

4th place: 1 point

Three-player pods:

1st place: 7 points

2nd place: 3 points

3rd place: 1 point

This point structure is designed to reward players for winning their pods while still recognizing consistent performance throughout the event.

A first-place finish is intentionally worth more than two second-place finishes combined, ensuring that players are heavily incentivized to compete for the win rather than simply aiming for safe finishes. This structure ensures that players who consistently win pods separate themselves at the top of the standings.

After all Swiss rounds are complete, players are ranked using tournament tie breakers including total points, wins, total opponent points, and average finish performance.

Top Cut

At the end of Swiss play, the highest-ranked players advance into the Top Cut.

The Top Cut size is determined by event size:

Exactly 8 players: No Top Cut

9–16 players: Top 4

17–64 players: Top 8

65+ players: Top 16

For 8-player events, all competitors complete the full Swiss stage and final standings are determined directly from Swiss results. Since the player field is already small, an additional playoff stage is not required to determine final placement.

For larger events, the Top Cut gives the highest-ranked Swiss players an opportunity to compete directly for the tournament's top placements.

Players who do not qualify for the Top Cut receive their final placement based on their Swiss standings.

During the Top Cut stage, each pod advances its top two finishers, narrowing the field each round until only the final four players remain.

Grand Final

The final four players advance to the Grand Final.

The player who finishes first is the tournament winner, and the remaining placements determine the final standings.

Seating

The recommended tournament software, Pod Play, has built-in Seat Balancing that attempts to normalize the amount of times each player is placed into a specific seat at a table.

If Pod Play is not being used, determine seating randomly before beginning game setup.